

Editorial

Shame on you

FOR OUR SECURITY special last month, we decided to conduct a little social experiment. We added in a little box on page 45 called “A forward you should ignore”, which basically told you that there was a way that you could get Gmail passwords of other people.

There are several reasons why this experiment should have failed:

1. The title of the box seemed descriptive enough.
2. The article it appeared in was about “social engineering”.
3. The entire magazine was centered around “Security”.
4. It was in *Digit*, and our readers are supposed to be “tech gurus”.

As of last count, over 1,100 people had happily parted with their own password, to try and get into someone else’s account — with the number increasing on a daily basis, this is hardly a failed experiment.

So here I am, sitting with over 1000 passwords, and potential access to a lot of your personal information. Although I’m not voyeuristic (and am not going to access your mail), all those of you who have sent me your passwords, are certainly quite the opposite.

Since I had to put your passwords to some good use, I decided to do a little data mining...

The very first trend that emerged, was that most of the respondents were male, and looking for passwords of females — so basically, a bunch of voyeurs, or stalkers. We even got a few dozen women looking for passwords of male friends, so apparently stalking isn’t gender-specific. It’s also quite apparent that no one really cares that hacking someone else’s email account is illegal — fines, jail terms, that kind of illegal.

It’s not just about snooping either; I found that most of you use really poor passwords. Simple keyboard combinations like “qwerty”, “123456” and “abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz” were common enough to upset me. What’s worse, a few people

were actually silly enough to put “password” as their password!

Almost all of the passwords used were under 8 characters long. Though it was quite interesting to note that a few of you were smart enough to use strong passwords — over 8 characters, with upper and lowercase letters, numbers and even punctuations — but dumb enough to fall for our little prank.

The most ridiculous trend was that between 10 and 15 per cent of you were using your mobile numbers as your passwords — so anyone who has ever called you could potentially hack into your account. Also, some people used their own names, or their postal codes.

A lot of guys out there seem to use girls’ names as their passwords, and of those, surprisingly, only about 10 per cent were looking for passwords for that same girl’s account. Interestingly, an equal amount were looking for the password to a different girl’s account — you two-timers, you know who you are.

Although fewer in number, the girls were more faithful, with most of the girls who had a boy’s name as their password, looking for that same boy’s login details — perhaps suspicious of the two-timing guys mentioned above?

Celebrity names were quite commonly used as passwords, with Aamir Khan and John Abraham being the most popular. Religious terms were also popular passwords, though being caught trying to hack another’s account is hardly ethical, let alone religious.

“Syncmaster” seems to be a popular monitor model, with enough of you using it as a password to get noticed. A few of you had “thinkdigit” as your password, and we’re flattered. One password actually read “iamaloser”.

Quite a few of you got conned by our little ruse, and tried to regain access to accounts that you had forgotten the passwords to, so we’ll be a



Robert Sovereign-Smith, Editor

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little less harsh on you, but you should realise that what you did could have lost you another account.

So what does all this tell me?

From where I sit, a lot of us Indians seem to be inquisitive — bordering on voyeuristic. Perhaps that’s why I know of women on our Thinkdigit forum who prefer to pose as men, just so they won’t get harassed. In this particular case, it doesn’t seem like the women are any less voyeuristic though.

I suppose I should be thankful that less than 1 per cent of our readership has fallen prey to this so far, but with millions of hoax mails reaching that same number on a regular basis, even a few thousand victims is cause for concern. Get your act together people — re-read our last month’s issue if necessary, but secure yourself from your own gullibility.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

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